

The Fourmidable's App Narrative



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Executive Summary of the App Transition and Project Hamilton

The complexity of the user-producer issue is the main point of inception for many media outlets, and it is one that the New York Post has seemingly mastered with the older generations. However, with the influx of digital content, and seemingly hard to reach Generation Z, the New York Post has fallen behind in digital innovation. Upon the inception of the SJU x New York Post collaboration this semester, it became evident that the app as a whole needed a facelift. With the proposed ideas on the new app, experience and overall feel of the digital presence of the New York Post. Our team went through extensive background research on features, feel, and overall difference makers for consumers when it comes to a news outlet's app. With the implementation of Project Hamilton, and the described rehaul of the app from the team at the New York Post, we went through and put together our thoughts on the current app and Project Hamilton in a Q&A styled approach to better describe what we saw and are convinced will improve The Post.

What We Love

Q: Which features do you love the most — and why?

Our team appreciated several features of the New York Post app that highlight the brand's strengths and make the experience engaging in unique ways. The most compelling aspect is the app's bold and instantly recognizable editorial identity. The high-contrast visuals, dramatic headlines, and energetic presentation establish a personality that feels instantly recognizable. The app delivers an experience that feels lively and full of momentum, which we believe is what appeals most to its existing audience, who tend to be from an older demographic.

We also valued the clarity of its navigation. Categories such as Top Stories, Page Six, Sports, and Opinion are presented in a format that is both familiar and intuitive. This makes browsing effortless, especially for readers who want to jump quickly between different types of content. The structure reflects a traditional news layout in a way that enhances usability rather than slowing it down.

Additionally, the app's fast update cycle stood out. With frequent push notifications and constant content refresh, the platform maintains a sense of immediacy. There is always something new to read, and this pace encourages habitual engagement. The breadth of content from breaking news to entertainment and sports further strengthens the experience by catering to multiple reading preferences within a single app.

Q: What made them stand out or feel different from other news apps?

The features that felt distinct because The Post fully embraces its tabloid roots, which makes the app feel more expressive and less standardized. Its bold style gives it a memorable character that differentiates it from polished competitors. The combination of clear navigation, high-volume content, and strong editorial voice creates an experience that feels fast, unapologetic, and full of identity, qualities that make the app stand out in a crowded news landscape.

What We Don't

Q: Which features didn't work for you — or you just didn't like?

While the app has meaningful strengths, several elements of the current design have limited our overall experience. The most prominent issue was the visual overload created by oversized headlines, dense imagery, and highly saturated layouts. Instead of drawing attention effectively, these elements compete with each other, making the interface feel overwhelming. We also struggled with the uniformity of the page layouts. Many screens appear visually similar, with little variation in typography or spacing to indicate hierarchy. This makes it harder to distinguish major stories from supporting content, slowing down the reading flow.

Another concern was the ad placement. When sensitive or serious stories are positioned directly next to bright, unrelated advertisements, the emotional tone shifts abruptly. This not only disrupts the reading experience but also affects the perceived credibility of the content. Finally, the app lacks a personalized or adaptive news feed. Unlike other platforms that tailor content based on user interests or reading patterns, every user receives the same experience. For younger readers who expect curated interfaces, this approach feels outdated.

Q: Why? Was it design, usability, content, or something else?

Most of the issues stem from a combination of design and usability challenges. The current visual style seems optimized for the app's traditional and likely older audience, who may prefer bold, tabloid-style presentation. However, Gen Z users tend to gravitate toward contemporary, streamlined design that feels light, spacious, and easy on the eyes. The app's intensity can feel jarring to younger readers who expect cleaner, more modern UI patterns.

The usability issues also arise from weak hierarchy and repetitive layouts, which make it difficult to quickly process information. Emotional inconsistency caused by ad placement further undermines the user's experience by interrupting the tone of serious stories. Finally, the lack of personalization affects long-term engagement. In an era where digital platforms adapt to individual behavior, the NY Post app's one-size-fits-all approach limits its relevance for audiences seeking tailored content.

Room for Improvement

Q: Which features could be improved or tweaked — and how would you do it?

Based on our team's review, there are several parts of the NY Post app that could be improved, particularly in areas where the current design creates friction or doesn't match up with what users expect from a modern mobile experience.

One of the most immediate opportunities lies in the visual layout and hierarchy. The Post's bold headlines and high-contrast aesthetic are recognizable strengths, but when it's carried over into a mobile environment, they create an experience that can feel crowded and visually overwhelming. Many students described the home screen as "intense" or "busy," making it difficult to skim through stories quickly. Adjusting headline size and adding clearer spacing between content would make the interface easier to navigate without sacrificing the brand's punchy style.

A second area of improvement is content organization across sections. Since most pages follow a uniform layout, most pages look identical, and users don't receive clear signals that they've moved into a new topic or category. Adding clearer visuals like fonts, color changes, or section dividers would help users navigate the app with more ease and spend less time searching for the stories that matter to them.

Another major concern is ad placement. When ads appear directly beside serious or sensitive stories, it creates an awkward and emotional feeling and makes the content/coverage feel less credible. Re-evaluating where and how ads appear would maintain revenue while creating a reading experience that feels more thoughtful and respectful.

Finally, the most consistent piece of feedback across students involved the lack of personalization. The app currently delivers the same content to everyone, which makes the experience feel static and not as connected to individual interests. A "For You" feed based on reading history, topic preferences, or followed categories would create a stronger sense of ownership and make individuals more likely to return to the app on a regular basis.

Q: If you could redesign or reimagine any features of the app, what would they be?

If we could reimagine one feature from the ground up, it would be Home Feed, the core of the mobile experience. The current layout mirrors the printed tabloid style, but today's modern mobile users expect a more flexible and engaging design.

A redesigned Home Feed could:

- Add short-form video summaries at the top for users who prefer visual updates
- Incorporate a scrolling menu of categories, giving users a faster way to jump between topics

- Introduce subtle motions to create moments of delight without distracting from the content
- These updates would maintain the Post's distinct identity while making the experience feel fresher, more organized, and more aligned with current mobile design standards.

Q: Native iOS/Android features you enjoy the most and would like to see on our app?

Integrating platform native features that could enhance the NY Post app experience:

- **Interactive widgets** for iOS/Android that surface top headlines directly on the home screen, keeping users engaged without opening the app.
- **Lock-screen Updates** for major breaking news moments, giving the Post real-time presence without requiring users to open the app
- **Push notifications** that adapt to individual reading habits
- **Quick swipe gestures** for navigating between articles, reducing the use of the back button

These features would create a more polished experience that users expect from top-tier news apps.

First Impressions & Feel

Q: Does the app feel modern and current to you?

Our team's first impression of the NY Post app was that it carries a strong brand presence, but it doesn't fully match the standards or expectations of a modern mobile experience. The bold, dramatic headlines, and high-contrast visuals immediately convey the Post's identity, yet the overall interface feels more like a desktop tabloid layout than a mobile friendly design.

Students often described the app as visually crowded, with limited spacing, minimal hierarchy, and oversized headlines that compete for attention. This bold style creates a sense of urgency and impact, but it also makes the interface feel older and more static compared to the designs of news platforms that Gen Z interacts with daily, such as Tiktok and Instagram, or even other news platforms like The Wall Street Journal and The New York Times. Those apps emphasize clean layouts, smoother visual flow, and personalization features that adapt to the user. By comparison, the NY Post app feels familiar and reliable, but not modern or innovative. The app feels established but does not evolve. The brand's voice is strong, but the overall interface could use updates that align with what today's users expect, focusing on simplicity, personalization, and more engaging content experience.

Q: Did any feature bring you a sense of surprise or delight the first time you saw it?

Although the overall design feels heavier and more crowded than most modern apps, a few elements did stand out in a positive way. We appreciated how quickly the app loads and how fast breaking news appears without lagging. Seeing headlines update in real time gives the app a dependable feel, it offers a sense of “always-on” news coverage, which resonates with users who value speed.

Additionally, the wide variety of content categories available directly from the navigation bar created a sense of accessibility. Users felt that, once they settled into the app, they could quickly jump between politics, sports, celebrity news, and opinion pieces without feeling lost. The variety of content stands out compared to other mobile apps.

However, the app doesn't offer any “delight moments”, the small touches that typically surprise users, such as animations, interactive visuals, or personalized content highlights. Today's mobile experiences often incorporate subtle elements that make the interface feel more alive. The Post app remains functional and direct but rarely offers those moments that make the interface feel special.

Habit & Retention

Q: What's the one feature that would make you come back daily?

The feature that would retain us as users to come back daily is the Hamilton tab, the ability for the tab to present the news our way, and also have it recap for us would allow for quick and digestible news. Nothing makes someone get the fear of missing out more than being out of the loop, and with the speed of Hamilton and its ability to provide the news in a personalized context, that fear is mitigated.

Q: What would make this app a part of your everyday routine? New ideas are most welcome!

Despite our differences from person to person, we all agreed that the Hamilton Tab is going to be a part of our daily routine. Being able to catch a few stories in the morning before work and have it in a user specific format will generate better click rates, and overall satisfaction. Then at the end of the day, after not being online, getting a quick recap, or the news presented once more in a very easy to read format we would be extremely excited to come back to the app daily as we see what we want in almost real time.

Ads & Value

Q: What's your idea of a "best with ads" experience?

The best with ads experience is one that doesn't impede the visual appeal of the app, while still maintaining the form of content publishing in the feed. We would all love to not have to see ads, but knowing that there will be, ads should flow as if they were a simple break between stories. Advertisements placed in the middle of an article are clunky, unappealing, and quite frankly reduce user experience and chances of still using the app.

Q: Would you prefer 1–2 video ads in exchange for a mostly ad-free experience?

Providing a YouTube style approach of advertisements can be an extremely beneficial method to explore. We believe that prefacing accessing the news mostly ad-free by watching a 30-second video will generate a very strong ad presence, while also improving the user experience, both very important metrics to have as a news corporation getting revenue from ads.

Q: Do you prefer the way ads currently appear in the app?

No, in fact it is one of the things we as a team liked the least, it felt abrupt and in poor taste. Location of ads alongside sensitive topics can create negative connotations to the company being advertised. On top of this, the ads placed in between paragraphs and other visuals are distracting. The attention span of a user must be kept and switching it on and off can lose someone.

Q: Would you consider paying for this app — if it offered a premium, ad-free, AI-enhanced news experience?

As a whole, if the true development of Hamilton, and a user-specific algorithm were implemented, we think there is a very good chance at garnering revenue through a paid subscription. Sports+ has been a well sung success for the New York Post, showing there is some want to exclusivity, and a paid method. Making the paid version affordable and truly beneficial to loyal consumers, or even new consumers would definitely make us considering paying.

Final Thoughts

Q: As a user, what would you like to see more of from the new app?

One of the most important things to a user is not feeling sold out, and we think the focus on the user is important but should not be used to simply be a revenue grab but really be dedicated to improving the user experience. The new app is great; we think that tweaking some of the aforementioned things would be our true recommendations. We really just think we want to see that the user is getting the bang for their attention or buck.

Q: If it were a paid experience, which features would you be willing to pay for?

Sports+, and a tailored Hamilton are two of the features we would definitely pay for. Being able to get an app to give you news in bites, instantly, and in a way that we as consumers love is the most important thing. Hamilton has extreme value, it can be worth the price to pay for it, especially for loyal users who want the most from the Post.

Q: Do you want to see more videos within your news app? Could you elaborate on that?

Yes and no, there is a definite balance. When we are consuming news in public, videos don't help if we can't listen, and the distracting environments we are in can be too much for an additional voice or sound. Videos are a great integration, and we think more should be present, but in moderation, as being conscious of consumption type can lead to a better personalized approach on videos for users.

Q: Which feature would you prioritize or move up to the MVP phase?

Prioritization of the "Personalized Hamilton Tab" is the main differentiator and should be the MVP phase's number one priority. If done correctly, the value add of having a user's own style of news be presented to them would drastically increase app engagement. The idea of having your own news style, content preferences, and personalization in your hands will drive many users to the app. Combine that with the Hamilton tab pushing notifications and you can create cyclic engagement on commutes, normal downtimes for a user, or the afternoon catchup.

Q: One last thing — how do you feel about the app name? Does it resonate with you? Does it feel modern, historic, or something else?

The app name is genius, and I think it is the perfect blend of old and new. This entire collaboration with the Post is centered around maintaining and improving the Post's outreach. We are inherently trying to bring in new, young users, while still providing for the older generation that overwhelmingly consumes the Post. Hamilton is the perfect historical blend into a modern feel, it feels more luxurious, it gives you a good feel to say, and it incorporates the rich history of the New York Post while focusing on the future.

Concluding Remarks

As a whole, we can say the current state of the New York Post app is behind in comparison to the revamp and facelift Project Hamilton will provide. We are confident that with our feedback as well as our strategic recommendations will help bolster Project Hamilton and make it the most valuable form of itself. With the goal of capturing GenZ while also ensuring that we maintain clearcut preferences for those who are native to the New York Post style, we can accurately adapt the app to create a differentiator for the New York Post. We believe our advice will continue to be applicable for GenZ for the future and are ready to stand by and provide clarity as the rollout of a new app and Project Hamilton go on.